



Opera's new "Ice" browser

Opera is preparing to reveal a new web browser called "Ice" for Android and iOS based tablets and smartphones soon



500px removed from App Store

Apple in a bid to stop pornography in its apps has removed the 500px photo sharing app from its App store as it was possible to find nudity using the app

Replacing SMS

Smartphone penetration is increasing by leaps and bounds in India thanks to handsets available at cheaper rates by the day. You can get a smartphone for as low as ₹5,000 nowadays. Short messaging service is slowly but surely on its way out as far as smartphone users are concerned. BlackBerry users have that taken care of with the BlackBerry Messenger service which is the preferred choice of messaging between two BlackBerry users. But for non-BlackBerry users there are many apps out there which can be used for messaging so long as you have a working data connection.

Hike

This is an indigenous app developed by Airtel's app-making arm - Bharti SoftBank Holdings (BSB). While it is similar to most mobile messaging apps allowing transfer of text, video and audio based messages over the internet connection, what is unique about this app is that it allows you to send upto 100 free SMSes to non-Hike users. If any of your friend accepts your invitation to join Hike you get 50 free SMSes. While you can send messages to friends who are



using Hike worldwide, the free SMS option is only open to Indian numbers. Incidentally, this app works better than WhatsApp on Windows Phone 8.

Website: <http://get.hike.in/>

Platform: Android, iOS, Windows Phone, Symbian, BlackBerry OS

Kik

This is another free-to-use mobile messaging app which works across platforms. Kik can work with either the phone number or with a Kik ID. It has an interesting feature in the form of cards, which is supported on some platforms. There are four cards: YouTube, Reddit pics, Sketch and Image Search. These cards can take you to the respective sites and you can share videos or pictures from these sites within Kik and they will appear as cards. Apart from this it has the regular messaging chops including the sent, delivered, read and typing notifications.

Website: <http://kik.com/>

Platform: Android, iOS, Windows Phone, Symbian, BlackBerry OS

Samsung ChatON

As expected, this app comes pre-loaded on all Samsung smartphones and allows you to send



text, images, videos, audio, share location, maps, calendar and contact information as well. You can create animated messages which is just like Kik's Sketch feature. There is a slight amount of gamification with a feature like Interaction Rank which ranks your contacts according to the frequency of your interaction. It works across platforms and requires your phone number to register just like other messaging apps. You can form your own groups,

Website: <https://web.samsung-chaton.com>
Platform: Android, Bada, iOS, BlackBerry OS, Symbian, PC

WeChat

This app from Chinese company Tencent is creating a lot of waves offshore thanks to its option to video chat and make voice calls



in addition to mobile messaging. It is available on all the major platforms and you can even login using your Facebook credentials. You do have to register your phone number with WeChat. You can add photos, send locations, make video calls or send across a voice message if you are too bored to type. You have options to customise your backgrounds while group chatting. It also comes with differentiating features such as Moments: which is like a social photo sharing which allows users to like or comment on your photos; LookAround: which allows you to see how far your friends are from you based on their locations; Shake: you shake your phone and you will come to know who else using WeChat has shook his or her phone and you can start a conversation with them and so on.

Website: <http://wechat.com/en/>

Platform: iOS, Android, BlackBerry OS, Symbian, Windows Phone, PC

Facebook Messenger

There were rumours last year that Facebook was planning to acquire WhatsApp, but they were just that. Facebook went ahead and



launched Facebook Messenger which allows you to login with your Facebook account as well as with your phone number. Even non-Facebook users can use this app by giving their number. You can send text or voice messages as well as share photographs. It has a free calling feature as well but it only works on iPhones and for users in the US and Canada. Website: <https://www.facebook.com/mobile/messenger>
Platform: Android, iOS, BlackBerry OS.

WhatsApp

This is the de-facto mobile messaging app that most smartphone users have as it is a cross platform app. So an Android user can communicate with a BlackBerry user and vice-versa. Actually, most of the apps we have listed are



cross-platform, but WhatsApp can safely be said to have started the trend. You can send text messages, images, videos as well as audio files. You can create groups of friends as well. This app even works on feature phones such as Nokia S40 ones which is a big plus in its favour. Another plus is that there is no advertising on the app, despite it being free of cost. Although WhatsApp says that the app is free only for a year and after a year they charge \$0.99 per year (around ₹55), we have to still come across too many users who have actually paid for using WhatsApp.

Website: www.whatsapp.com

Platform: Apple iOS, Android, BlackBerry OS, Symbian, Windows Phone, Symbian S40